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Just a Little Bend on the S-Curve: The Rise and Fall of Linguistic Change in Post-Classical Biblical Hebrew

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ABSTRACT: The paper deals with the text-critical challenge and the variationist analysis in application to the historical linguistics of Biblical Hebrew, coming out in recent research, particularly in *Historical Linguistics and Biblical Hebrew* by Robert Rezetko and Ian Young (2014). Different textual transmissions have become part of the linguistic corpus and an indispensable part of historical-linguistic research. Variationist analysis corroborates that some explicit innovative processes in the standard literary idiom of the Persian period were reversed by the conservative tendency, distinctive in the Qumran corpus, so that it will be more accurate to speak about two different stages in Late Biblical Hebrew development: Persian period and Late Hellenistic—early Roman periods.

Key words: Biblical Hebrew, Historical linguistics, Textual criticism

1. Foreword

In the last decade, the historical study of Biblical Hebrew (BH) has become the ground for vivid debates.¹ The year 2014 was marked by two milestone publications—A Concise Lexicon by Avi Hurvitz (written in collaboration with Leeor Gottlieb, Aaron Hornkohl and Emmanuel Mastéy) and Historical Linguistics by Robert Rezetko and Ian Young. These two books summarize the discussion in the perspective of contrasting attitudes, address central methodological problems, and point in the direction of further development. As expected, the books are quite opposite in their attitude—Hurvitz 2014 celebrates almost a jubilee of “traditional” research on linguistic innovations in Late Biblical Hebrew (LBH) with a compact (280 pages) and elegant investigation of eighty lexical items and phrases. Rezetko and Young 2014

*Many topics of this essay were discussed by the author with Martin Eherenvards and Aaron Hornkohl; Aaron also read the preliminary version of the essay. I thank them for their previous comments; all the responsibility remains mine.

1. See, e.g., Young, Rezetko and Eherenvards 2008, Miller-Naudé and Zevit 2012, Joosten 2012c, Kim 2013, Hornkohl 2014, Fassberg 2016, Rezetko and Naaijer 2016, Samet 2016, to mention just a few.

(R&Y) is a lengthy (721 pages) opus that in its application of two frameworks—Cross-Textual Variable Analysis (CTVA) and Variationist Analysis (VA)²—challenges the trustworthiness of the field in general, claiming three *nulli*: (a) there is no reliable textual basis for the historical-linguistic analysis of BH, in other words we face the problem of “very bad data”;³ (2) the historical-linguistic analysis of BH allows for no clear-cut and consistent conclusions;⁴ (3) the linguistic dating of Biblical texts is not possible in view of the very ambiguous data.⁵

In this essay I would like to concentrate on some key developments in the field of the historical linguistics of BH in recent years; significant focus will be laid on the work of R&Y, who typically point at the most vulnerable and challenging aspects of the subject. Particularly, I will touch on two issues that have attracted much of the scholarly attention: In section 2 I will discuss the growing practice of encompassing textual criticism into historical-linguistic research, which has resulted in a decisive change in the research paradigm. I will concentrate on what is supposed to be the main contribution of the CTVA method, suggested by R&Y, namely their distributional analysis of

2. For these methodological attitudes and their potential interrelation cf. R&Y: 119: “The essence of CTVA is that divergent texts or manuscripts of the same composition, which we call *multiversion literature*, can be used by the historical linguist, or historical sociolinguist, to explore, classify, and count individual variations, groups of variations, and, if any, patterns of variation, and these in turn can be used as a foothold to gain insight into the reasons behind those variations, including diachronic, diatopic, diastratic, diaphasic, diasituative, and/or other sociolinguistic determinants of variation;” cf. also pp. 48–49 for this terminology. I am not sure whether the authors succeeded in the integration of the linguistic variation and text-critical data; see R&Y: 254 and cf. below.

3. See R&Y p. 120, 203, 210, 242 and in particular the discussion in chapters 4, 5, and 6.

4. Although R&Y promise to be constructive and with the help of “cross-textual variable analysis and variationist analysis <...> to get a much better grasp on the linguistic facts of BH, and therefore to formulate eventually a better history of ancient Hebrew” (p. 57), readers will not find any positive linguistic ‘story’ in the book; the conclusions driven from the analysis are overwhelmingly pessimistic; cf. p. 242, 263, 289, 318–325, 352, 371, 394. For alternative conclusions drawn from their research see below.

5. R&Y (see pp. 4–5 and particular ch. 2) promise a book not on “linguistic dating”, which in their understanding is a marginal area of historical linguistics (cf. p. 17), but on linguistic change, aiming to explain “*how* and *why* variation and change occur” (p. 15). However, the main overtone of the conclusions in ch. 8 is all about the impossibility of dating texts linguistically; cf. p. 247: “the evidence as a whole calls into question any use of such a rare form to situate biblical writings chronologically or sequence them in any particular order;” see also pp. 263, 270, or p. 274: “the evidence as a whole calls into question any use of such a rare form to situate biblical writings chronologically or sequence them in any particular order” and p. 278: “cannot serve to date texts linguistically”, etc. In fact, linguistic dating remained the focus of the authors’ concern.

common and less common linguistic features. I claim that the notion of “common and less common” linguistic features is methodologically unsound and that the alternative approach, which endorses meticulous text-critical and philological study of each case in correlation to a more general examination of sources, still provides a more suitable tool for the field of historical linguistics. In section 3 I will turn to variationist analysis in the service of historical linguistics, as it has lately been applied in BH studies. I will concentrate on two important types of input that the VA brings to light: (1) that the development from CBH to LBH did not result in radical systemic changes, but rather was limited to certain tendencies in variation; in other words the assumed typical S-curve of linguistic change rarely reached its climax or even the midpoint of “early majority” adoption; (2) Qumran Hebrew demonstrates a remarkable example of the conservative reversal of the linguistic change trajectory and results in a considerable decline of some innovative patterns. Both tendencies, particularly the latter one, were consistently outlined by R&Y, although, biased by their “very bad data” model, they did not provide any reasonable explanation for them. It will be claimed that the developmental reversal was caused by general conservative tendencies, characteristic for Hebrew of the late Hellenistic—early Roman periods. Section 4 summarizes.

2. *The Linguistics of Textual Variation*

The “traditional” historical-linguistic study of BH, as exemplified in the method of Avi Hurvitz, has been based mainly on the Masoretic Text (MT) as the only complete Hebrew source, as opposed to the fragmentary Qumran paleographic data and the ancient translations.⁶ The notion of MT priority is typical of synchronic studies on BH linguistics as well.⁷ However, recent advances in textual criticism rooted in intensive research on Qumran textual data, as well as on the Septuagint and Samaritan Pentateuch, have opened new perspectives for linguists.⁸ The recognition of historical-linguistic im-

6. Cf. Hurvitz 1982: 19. He however specifies that “this procedure is not followed out of an axiomatic belief in the supremacy of MT, nor does it imply that it has reached us in exactly the same form in which it left the hands of the ancient writers....However, at the same time it seems to us that a linguistic study whose central purpose it to seek facts and avoid conjectures, should base itself on *actual* texts – difficult though they might be – rather than depend on *reconstructed* texts.” The same approach is evident in Hurvitz 2014, where, however, non-Masoretic textual sources are routinely cited as evidence of LBH phenomena.

7. Cf. Miller 2003: 18: “wholesale emendation of the text will be avoided, following common practice in linguistic studies” and Moshavi 2010: 5. The MT priority is assumed in Cook 2012a (with no discussion of the textual basis) and Holmstedt 2016, cf. pp. 17-18.

8. On the general advance of textual criticism cf., for example, Tov 2005, 2009, 2012, Ulrich 2011a, 2011b, 2012, 2015, Lange 2009, Lange, Weigold, and Zsengellér 2009, Schorch 2012, 2013, 2015, Kloppenborg and Newman 2012, Hendel 2010, 2016, to mention just a few. As for the origin of the MT in relation to

portance in different textual versions is by no means new; the approach goes back to the fundamental research of Yehezkel Kutscher on the linguistic background of the Great Isaiah Scroll.⁹ Recently, ground-breaking research on the linguistic setting of different textual variations and recensions, prompted by the increasing importance of the BH linguistics, has been conducted.¹⁰

Incorporating textual variation in the historical study of BH is an important part of R&Y's approach. Their method and objectives have some hallmarks: (1) they do not accept any typology of the textual evidence, but rather give equal rank to all the existing data;¹¹ (2) they do not suggest philological discussions on particular textual readings, preferring big-data statistical analysis;¹² (3) they evaluate textual variations in terms of the criterion of "common and less common linguistic features" (see below); (4) their analysis is explicitly aimed at putting forward the "very bad data" premise, claiming that the MT is not reliable for historical-linguistic analysis and that there is no available text-critical practice that would allow for identifying the "original text", foundational, in their view, for linguistic research.¹³

The text-critical discussion of R&Y, put through in terms of the CTVA, examines two kinds of data—parallel texts within the Hebrew Bible itself and

other editorial traditions, there are different theories; cf. for example the reviews in Lange 2009 and Handel 2010: there are good reasons to admit that the consonantal MT is a result of an editorial project, triggered within the context of Hellenistic philological activity, eclectic in its method, but striving to be based on a 'correct' version. This does not mean that their choice was always according to modern sensibilities.

9. See Kutscher 1974. According to R&Y 69-70, 136-137, Kutscher a priori privileged the textual version of MT over 1QIsa^a; cf. R&Y 137: "One manuscript should not be privileged over another one (whether 1QIsa^a or L) and a newer textual artifact (L) *may* have earlier language than an older one (1QIsa^a). Kutscher ignored the first point and overtly argued the second one." However it would be misleading to say that Kutscher's conclusions about the character of the language in 1QIsa^a are based on the ultimate priority given to MT; they are rather the *result* of scrupulous and persuasive philological and linguistic analysis.

10. The historical-linguistic background of different inter-textual variations is studied in particular in Joosten 2000, 2007, 2012a, 2013b, 2012b, 2015a, 2015b, Mizrahi 2011, 2013a, 2013b, 2015, 2017, Hornkohl 2014b, 2017, Holmstedt 2013.

11. Cf. the well-formulated approach of Tov 2004, 2013, who consistently divided the Qumran biblical scrolls into proto-masoretic, proto-septuagint, proto-samaritan, sectarian, and non-aligned. His theory is not accepted by all, but cf. Hendel 2010.

12. Cf. R&Y 78-79.

13. Chapters 3-6 of R&Y, focusing on textual criticism, are a crusade against the MT, or, rather, against what they call "the assumption that the Hebrew language of the MT represents largely unchanged the actual language used by the original authors of biblical writings;" cf. p. 59 and particularly pp. 68-71. Moreover, other sorts of textual evidence are equally disqualified due to continuous processes of redactional activity, see R&Y 67: "In short, the textual witnesses are nonauthentic, composite, and largely unsituated in time and place."

different Hebrew versions of given Biblical compositions—compiling differences in long charts in appendixes. Their conclusions, however, are based on particularly selected data, namely on statistically represented distributions of what they call “less common linguistic features.” They claim that “while the basic features shared by almost every BH writing are quite stable in their textual transmission, the specific linguistic details of the biblical compositions were fluid, in particular the less common linguistic forms” (p. 110). The “common” linguistic features are those that are shared by most writings and are stable in transmission, while the “less common” linguistic features are those that appear just in some writings and tend to vary in parallels and versions. They exclude from the category of the “less common” features the unique (*hapax legomenon*), specific, or non-contrasted forms, and claim that the “less common forms” are less frequent members of linguistic oppositions; practically speaking, the “less common features” are those associated with the LBH lexicon and phraseology (p. 113): “these five books [Esther, Daniel, Ezra, Nehemiah, and Chronicles] in the form we know them are distinguished by their quantifiably higher accumulations of some linguistic features that are less common in most other MT biblical books.”¹⁴

Analyzing parallel texts, e.g. Ps 18 and 2 Sam 22, the authors maintain that almost none of the “less common linguistic features” are shared by these texts and conclude that “our current texts are unlikely to provide any access back to the linguistic features of the earliest stages of composition of this chapter” (p. 158).¹⁵ A reader who would like to verify which “less common features” are not shared by these texts, provoking such dramatic conclusions, faces a very tiresome business: there is *not a single* example in the corresponding chapter, just two charts with some statistics in support of the authors’ claim. A search for examples in Appendix 1 (pp. 413–421) brings references to: the less common את plus suffix in 2 Sam 22:20 vs. the common verbal suffix in Ps 18:20; the less common וְאֵהִי in 2 Sam 22:24 vs. the more common form וְאֵהִי in Ps 18:24; the more common feminine form כְּצִדְקָתִי in 2 Sam 22:25 vs. the less common masculine form כְּצִדְקִי in Ps 18:25; the more common form מִמִּסְגְּרוֹתָם in 2 Sam 22:46 vs. the less common third person masculine plural suffix on a feminine plural noun -וְתִיהֶם in Ps 18:46; the less

14. Cf. the discussion in R&Y 153–155; p. 153: “In this study we look at linguistic forms that are both involved in a clear linguistic opposition with other forms, and which are the less common forms in the MT as a whole. By “linguistic opposition” we mean, according to the simple, classic sense well known from the works of Hurvitz, that the linguistic feature is equivalent in meaning and used in place of another linguistic item(s).”

15. Their conclusion is based on a premise, that (R&Y 153): “if the language of the MT represents the end product of a faithful transmission of the linguistic features of the biblical compositions, it necessarily follows that this should be reflected in these parallel texts. If, on the contrary, the linguistic features of these parallel texts turn out to be in any significant way divergent, this would be strong evidence that the details of the language of the biblical compositions have not been carefully or faithfully preserved in textual transmission.”

common second element of the construct in plural *המסים* in 2 Sam 22:49 vs. more common in singular *המס* in Ps 18:49, etc. This list gives a very strange impression; it is not always clear what the “less common” forms have in common and why their apparent fluidity prevents any access to the linguistic features of the composition.¹⁶

In general, the terminology of “common” and “less common” linguistic features seems idiosyncratic and circular. The terminology is not used in linguistics, or at least not in the way R&Y use it: one speaks about common features in languages if these characteristics correspond to universal parameters or are cross-linguistically confirmed, but this is obviously not the case here. Even the terms “standard” and “peripheral features,” employed in dialectology and sociolinguistics, are used differently: peripheral features are to be explicitly associated with certain linguistic peripheries—dialect, jargon, register, type of discourse, convention, etc. R&Y do not succeed in identifying their “less common” features with any of these domains. The claim that the textual instability of “less common” features makes the texts unreliable is obscure: if “less common features” are not identified with any linguistic periphery, but are simply present as sporadic components in an opposition, they are by definition unstable, random, and irregular elements. Their instability does not necessarily prevent access to the linguistic features of the composition. But if the “less common” features are nevertheless associated with a concrete linguistic periphery—namely with LBH vocabulary and grammar—their instability in different textual versions is more than predictable: they might be due to sporadic uses, editorial intrusions, harmonizing, etc. In summary, the linguistic and text-critical status of the notion of “less common linguistic features” is very shaky as grounds for asserting unreliability of the text for linguistic analysis. At best, the analysis of the distribution of LBH features in different textual data demonstrates that particular manuscripts do not necessarily bear witness to a concrete textual recension, precisely located on the temporal and spatial axis of textual development. Meanwhile the CTVA, concentrating on the statistical distribution of “less common linguistic features,” appears quite ineffective for the linguistic study of BH.¹⁷

Furthermore, the assumed reconstruction of the “original” text, formulated in R&Y,¹⁸ is a much debated issue in textual criticism and, moreover, not

16. The analysis of the ‘common and less common’ features in the textual evidence of the book of Samuel is more representative in data (cf. chapter 7, in particular pp. 180-181), but the methodology is dubious in its foundation; see below.

17. The recommendations of R&Y as to how to do BH linguistics by excluding “the less common features”, in view of the “very bad data” premise, are somewhat confusing and do not co-opt with corpus-linguistics attitude (cf. below); p. 112: “We can still do linguistic analysis on the biblical texts, but we need to be clear about what we are doing. Only large-scale and basic features of the language of the biblical compositions are likely to go back to earlier stages of their literary composition.” One can just imagine the next generation of grammar books – “A Biblical Hebrew Grammar of the Common, Large-scale, and Basic Features”!

18. Cf. in particular R&Y: 60-61, 75-77.

necessarily a prerequisite of for historical linguistic analysis. Linguistics, working with a definite corpus, such as the Hebrew Bible, is to be based on corpus-driven data, whatever the nature of the corpus, taking its specific characteristics into consideration. For BH linguistics the data embraces not only MT, but all the relevant textual evidence, including paleographic material and the ancient versions, as is noted also by R&Y. The given data is neither very good nor very bad; it is natural, sufficiently extensive, and representative to serve as a corpus for linguistic research.¹⁹ In view of textual variation, a more adequate strategy is to look for better, more reliable (rather than “original”) readings in each particular case and to explore the relationship between different readings, cognate cases, and, whenever possible, alternative textual recensions.²⁰ Even if we cannot date books and manuscripts primarily on linguistic grounds, we can tell a story about linguistic development, i.e., concentrate on the real goal of historical linguistics.

3. Not All Curves Are Perfect

In search of stricter methods, BH historical linguistics has turned to sociolinguistic VA. The method is quantitative and based on the correlation of true linguistic variables (opposing expressions with the same value) and independent non-linguistic variables (chronological, stylistic, dialectal, discursive, etc.); the latter suggest a constraint on the distribution of the former. This correlation is routinely represented as an S-curve graph, but can be also treated in other terms. The method has been applied to BH data in some recent studies, and has proved to be particularly promising.²¹

The VA method plays an important role in the R&Y’s linguistic investigation. They choose to concentrate mostly on lexical issues: the verbal lexemes

19. On the Hebrew Bible as a linguistic corpus see van der Merwe 2010; Miller 2004; Holmstedt 2006, 2012; cf. also the review in Moshavi and Notarius 2017: 4-6. As has been claimed in the latter research, the written literary character of the sources is not to be underestimated in historical linguistics: in written and oral languages the competence is the same, but the performance strategies are different; see Halliday 1971; cf. the discussion in Notarius 2014. The fact that ancient texts transmitted traditionally have ‘noise’, namely built-in uncertainty concerning textual evidence, is not new in linguistics. The significance of this ‘noise’ however decreases if the number of tokens illustrating linguistic change increases; cf. the discussion in Forbes 2012, 2016a, 2016b.

20. Cf. the approach formulated in the introduction to *Biblical Hebraica Quinta*: pp. XV – XVII, Hendel 2008 and 2016, see particularly pp. 145-147; Tov 2012: 280-281. The text-critical approach of R&Y seems self-contradictory. They presume together with many authors that there are no fixed textual patterns that would automatically elucidate the differences between different versions (see the works in footnote 8 above and in particularly Ulrich 2015); even if there are groups of manuscripts (as is consistently claimed by Tov), each specific reading may have its own story. The lack of the precise patterning of textual data a priori does not work together with the large-scaled statistical analysis, suggested in R&Y.

21. See Drescher 2012, Holmstedt 2012, Cook 2012, Kim 2013, Screnock 2018; cf. the review in R&Y 238-243.

דַּרְשׁ “study (the deity’s law)” contrasted to שָׁמַר; ten cases of contrasted “early” vs. “late” verbs: חָפַז, מָהֵר, בָּהֵל // דָּחָף, “be in a hurry”; רָגַז, פָּחַד, יָרָא, חָרַד, “gather,” כָּנַס // אָסַף, קָבַץ, “cry,” זָעַק // צָעַק, “go,” Qal // Piel “be afraid,” הִלֵּךְ Qal // Piel “receive,” קָבַל // לָקַח, “arise,” עָמַד // קוּם, “be angry,” כָּעַס // קִצַּף, חָרָה ± אָף Hiphil // Piel “raise,” מָשַׁל // שָׁלַט “rule”; the nominal lexemes מַלְכוּת // מַמְלָכָה, and some morphological tokens: abstract nouns in -וּת;²² the pronominal endings -וֹתָם // -וְהֵימָּן, and the directive ה contrasted to other ways of expressing direction.²³ Strikingly, the authors highlight the well-known and thoroughly discussed tokens of lexical (and morphological) variation in the hope that the new method will allow for a more accurate understanding of the same data; typically, they do not investigate any previously unknown cases of linguistic variation. Moreover, the authors are indifferent to other potentially relevant factors, such as dialectal or typological considerations, and leave any cross-linguistic evidence outside the scope of their discussion: they ignore the dialectal evidence about the dissimilation of emphatics in זָעַק // צָעַק and the analogical developments of -וֹתָם / -וְהֵימָּן;²⁴ and are not sensitive to the typology of the Qal > Piel transition in LBH and Mishnaic Hebrew (MH).²⁵

R&Y’s “putting old wine into new bottles” is not useless; the authors demonstrate some sound and eminent tendencies in the historical-linguistic development on the axis from CBH to Qumran Hebrew (QH), although they themselves fail to acknowledge their own findings. With the help of the graphs that represent the distribution of variants in absolute (numbers of concrete cases) and relative (percentage) terms R&Y demonstrate the following phenomena:

(1) The dynamism of linguistic change on the interval from CBH to LBH (associated with Hebrew of the Persian period) is relatively low, the change is not dramatic, and there is no place to talk about a radical systemic shift.²⁶ The curve of linguistic change for most of the phenomena under discussion is never perfectly shaped or reaches its climax of full acceptance. Rather for most cases the acceptance of the phenomena in the corpus of LBH does not surpass 50-60 percent (cf. בָּהֵל, דָּחָף, figure 8.4 p. 267, שָׁלַט figure 8.24 p. 317, כָּעַס Qal figure 8.14 p. 293, קוּם Piel figure 8.22 p. 313, וְהֵימָּן figure 9.6 p. 365), as a rule remaining around 20 percent (דַּרְשׁ + deity’s law figure 8.2 p. 259, הִלֵּךְ Piel figure 8.8 p. 277, קָבַל Piel figure 8.20 p. 309, כָּעַס figure 8.12 p. 287, עָמַד “arise” figure 8.18 p. 301), with the clear exception of מַלְכוּת, which arrives at almost 80-90 percent acceptance in LBH

22. For this token R&Y abandon their own method and do not contrast two variants, i.e., they do not deal with other ways of expressing abstract nominal semantics, such as, in particular, nominal patterns and plural.

23. See R&Y chapters 8-9.

24. See Garr 45-45, 97-99; see also Wikander 2015.

25. See Fassberg 2001.

26. The conclusions are based on the tokens selected in R&Y; cf. in their own terms, p. 261: “there is not much of an s-curve in the plot of the linguistic data.” They find partial support in some other research on LBH and QH, carried out within other methodological standpoints; cf. for example the contribution of Cohen 2013.

corpus (cf. figure 9.4 p. 343). The innovative tokens in the Hebrew of the Persian period exhibit growing tendencies, but did not exceed the initial stage of expansion, hardly reaching the advanced stage, while the old tokens still preserved most of their usages.

(2) R&Y's analysis demonstrates a remarkable developmental phenomenon in the interval from LBH to QH (including Ben Sira in most cases), i.e., at the period associated with the late Hellenistic—early Roman Periods: QH unambiguously attests a decline in the use of most of the innovative tokens under discussion. The phenomenon is made evident by means of the conservative rise of old tokens (cf. *ותם*- figure 9.5 p. 364, *ממלכה* figure 9.3 p. 342, *קום* Hifil figure 8.21 p. 312, *קום* Qal figure 8.17 p. 300, *קצה*, *חרה* ± *אף* figure 8.13 p. 292, *קבץ*, *אסף* figure 8.11 p. 286, *לקח* figure 8.19 p. 308, *הלך* Qal figure 8.7 p. 276, *רגו*, *פחד*, *ירא*, *חרד* figure 8.5 p. 272, *חפו*, *מהר* figure 8.3 p. 266, *משל* figure 8.23 p. 316).²⁷ As a result the graph of acceptance for many of the innovative phenomena under discussion decreases by 20 or more percent—the process that deforms the positively growing bend of the S-curve, illustrating a conservative reversal of the innovative processes apparently typical of QH (cf. *ותיהם* figure 9.6 p. 365, *מלכות* figure 9.4 p. 343, *קום* Piel figure 8.22 p. 313, *קום* Qal figure 8.18 p. 301, *כעס* Qal figure 8.14 p. 293, *כעס* Qal figure 8.14 p. 293, *קבל* Piel figure 8.20 p. 309, *הלך* Piel figure 8.8 p. 277, *בעת* Ni figure 8.6 p. 273, *בהל*, *דהר* figure 8.4 p. 267, *שלט* figure 8.24 p. 317).²⁸ It looks like the historical-linguistic developmental reversal in QH, illustrated in the case studies of R&Y, is rooted in a general conservative tendency, characteristic of Hebrew in the late Hellenistic—early Roman period.²⁹

27. This development correlates with the use of classicisms, typical of some LBH sources, and of the writings from Qumran in particular, discussed by Joosten 1999, 2000, 2012d, 2013a, and 2016, cf. Joosten 2013a: “Although new words, particularly Aramaic loanwords, had entered the language, later authors often avoided using them, and kept to the vocabulary of ‘classical’ texts <...> as much as possible. Similarly, although the grammar of Hebrew had evolved, writers of the Second Temple period attempted to stay close to the usage of the earlier texts;” see also Weitzman 1999, Schniedewind 1999, Kister 2013. Scholars have particularly noticed the cases in which the pseudo-classicisms are identified due to ‘slips’ in using classical tokens. This conclusion does not violate the general scholarly observation that LBH and QH have a lot of common characteristics and that the latter is a continuation of the former; see Qimron 1986: 88–97 and Qimron 2009.

28. What is the decrease in classical features in Qumran scrolls that the authors have unambiguously pointed at, if not a pattern that needs an explanation? However they prefer to use these data as another indication of the overwhelming chaos reigning the field of the BH historical linguistics. Cf. R&Y: 394, 400.

29. It is clear that not all the linguistic innovations of the Persian period were reversed in the Qumran period and that the historical-linguistic status of QH is to be described in view of many typical innovations. The innovative vs. conservative tendencies vary depending on the phenomena under discussion and part of the corpora, cf. Fassberg 2015 on Aramaisms, and more research published in the proceedings of the yearly International Symposium on the Hebrew of the Dead Sea Scrolls and Ben Sira: Muraoka and Elwolde 1997, Muraoka and Elwolde 1999, Muraoka and

4. Conclusion

The text-critical challenge has become part of the historical-linguistic method: on the one hand, large-scope statistical analysis of inter-textual variations in terms of more and less common features is no substitute for meticulous text-critical work on different readings in parallel sources; on the other hand, the different textual transmissions have become part of the linguistic corpus in general and an indispensable part of the historical-linguistic research.

VA resulted in a significant contribution to the field of BH historical linguistics: it unambiguously illustrated two remarkable historical-linguistic phenomena in the Hebrew of the Second Temple period—(1) the initial rise of some explicit linguistic developments in the standard literary idiom of the Persian period, most probably under the intensive influence of Aramaic and other foreign and vernacular practices, and (2) the conservative reversal of many of these innovative processes, distinctive of the early Hellenistic—late Roman periods.³⁰ As a result of this fine distinction one can speak with more security of two different stages in the development of Post-Classical BH: BH of the Persian period and BH of the Late Hellenistic—early Roman periods. The socio-linguistic implications of this distinction are to be evaluated in the future research.³¹

Elwolde 2000, Joosten and Rey 2008, Fassberg, Bar-Asher and Clements 2013, Tigchelaar and Hecke 2015; for a nuanced approach to QH see Reymond 2015. Unfortunately, Mishnaic Hebrew (MH) is almost never included in the analysis of R&Y (except for the cases of מלכות and וְתָהִם / וְתִהְיֶה): typically, in both these cases Mishnaic Hebrew does not continue the reversal tendency of QH, illustrating a clear, up to 100 percent acceptance of the innovative token. This data contributes to the view that MH is a typologically different linguistic stage, rather than a continuation of QH; cf. Qimron 2009.

30. R&Y's own conclusion of their research is to be disqualified in my eyes: cf. 402: "The results of our case studies in this book and elsewhere indicate to us that the common linguistic features of BH appear relatively stable in the biblical sources—both within the MT and between the MT and other texts. Large-scale linguistic invariance of this sort is quite normal for literature that is written in a High dialect or standard literary language. However, the less common linguistic features are highly fluid—again both within the MT and between the MT and other texts. Because these variations, especially the distribution of the so-called late linguistic forms and uses, do not appear to systematically align with any identifiable or hypothetical chronological or regional pattern of variation, we continue to think that "style" is a plausible and significant factor behind the distribution of many of these linguistic variants in the Bible." On the obscurity and misunderstanding of their common vs less common linguistic features see above; the "style" factor was never consistently licensed as an independent variable in the course of their research, therefore the reference to it in the conclusion seems bizarre.

³¹ For the possible extra-linguistic background of this development see Wise 2015: 285; he drives parallel between the literacy in Roman Judaea and the rhetoric of Atticism that aims at the revival of classical models in Greek writing of the first and second century CE. I thank Jan Joosten who brought this discussion to my attention.

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